



She Drew Small

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The article, marked for rhetorical devices:

- 1 She told the story of a revolution in the drawings of a child, and that turned out to be the truest way to tell it. Marjane Satrapi, who died in Paris on Thursday at fifty-six, made her name with a black-and-white comic about a girl in Tehran. The girl was herself.
- 2 Persepolis began appearing in 2000, four slim volumes of line drawings: a daughter of educated, watchful parents growing up as the Iran of her childhood was remade around her, then sent abroad to Europe, alone and young. The drawings were plain. [paragraph 2: understatement / litotes] A veil, a schoolyard, a soldier at a corner. [paragraph 2: asyndeton] Out of those small panels came a portrait of a country that years of reporting had left, for most outside readers, a blur.
- 3 That was her method, and her quiet argument: that the enormous is best approached through the small [paragraph 3: antithesis (small vs large)]. A revolution rendered as a quarrel with her grandmother. Exile rendered as a teenager friendless in a borrowed language. [paragraph 3: parallelism (not anaphora)] She trusted the particular to carry the general, and it did.
- 4 And in 2007 she and Vincent Paronnaud turned the books into an animated film, keeping the stark black and white when color would have been easier and more salable. It shared the Jury Prize at Cannes. It was nominated for the Academy Award for best animated feature, and with that nomination Satrapi became the first woman the category had ever named. She went on to other things: a novel and film called Chicken with Plums, books drawn at a kitchen table, films in registers far from where she began, and, near the end, a book that gathered Iranian artists under the slogan woman, life, freedom.
- 5 Her family said she died of grief, a year after the death of her husband, Mattias Ripa. It is the kind of cause a doctor does not certify and a reader of her work does not doubt. She had always written as if private feeling and public history were the same material, seen at different distances.
- 6 She drew small so that the world could see something large. [paragraph 6: antithesis (payoff)] Her books remain the clearest window many readers will ever have [paragraph 6: metaphor] onto a place they were taught to fear [paragraph 6: pathos], and they will go on doing that work quietly, in black and white, long after the hand that drew them is still.

Quick reference (devices used):

- Paragraph 2: understatement / litotes; asyndeton
- Paragraph 3: antithesis (small vs large); parallelism (not anaphora)
- Paragraph 6: antithesis (payoff); metaphor; pathos

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The three-word sentence “The girl was herself.” most directly functions to
 - A) cast doubt on the accuracy of Satrapi’s account
 - B) reveal the autobiographical basis of the work in a single, quiet stroke
 - C) introduce a fictional character for contrast
 - D) shift the passage from praise to complaint
2. Describing “private feeling and public history” as “the same material, seen at different distances” chiefly serves to
 - A) state the governing antithesis that small personal scenes can carry large historical meaning
 - B) criticize historians for neglecting private life
 - C) summarize the plot of Persepolis for the reader
 - D) urge readers to write their own memoirs

Multiple choice answer key:

1. **Answer B.** The clipped sentence (syntax) delivers the key fact, that the memoir is her own life, with the restraint the piece prizes.
2. **Answer A.** It restates the small-and-large antithesis that organizes the piece, a claim already demonstrated rather than asserted.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer handles an unverifiable cause of death (“her family said she died of grief”) in a single sentence. How does the next line turn that uncertainty into a statement about her work?
2. A tribute risks tipping into sentimentality. Point to two specific choices here (consider the understatement in paragraph 2) that keep the praise restrained rather than gushing.

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The writer reports the family’s claim (‘died of grief’) rather than asserting it, then turns it: a doctor ‘does not certify’ the cause but a reader ‘does not doubt’ it. The move converts an uncertain fact into a statement about her art, that she treated private feeling and public history as one material.
2. Restraint shows in the understatement (‘the drawings were plain’), the refusal to pile on superlatives, and a close that places her in a longer history rather than issuing a call to action. The praise is carried by concrete images, not by adjectives.

Writing prompt (homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The writer claims that private feeling and public history are ‘the same material, seen at different distances.’ Defend, challenge, or qualify this claim, using your own reading, study, or experience.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Students often mislabel the 'rendered as ... rendered as ...' run as anaphora. It is parallelism: the repeated element falls in the middle, not at the start of each clause.
- Calling the drawings 'plain' is understatement, not literal description; the point is that small means carry large meaning.
- 'Pathos' here lives in concrete nouns ('a place they were taught to fear'), not in emotion-words.

AP exam alignment:

Q2 rhetorical-analysis value: strong for teaching antithesis as a structural engine and for the parallelism-versus-anaphora distinction. The epideictic (tribute) mode is a useful contrast to argument passages.